

Six Thinking Hats

Separate emotion, facts, caution, optimism, creativity and process

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Six Thinking Hats is a parallel-thinking method in which a group deliberately adopts one 'hat' — one mode of thinking — at a time: **White** (facts), **Red** (feelings), **Black** (caution), **Yellow** (optimism), **Green** (creativity) and **Blue** (process control). Everyone thinks in the same mode simultaneously, avoiding adversarial argument.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Created by Maltese physician and cognition author Edward de Bono, introduced in his 1985 book *Six Thinking Hats*.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

In normal meetings people defend fixed positions and argue past each other. De Bono wanted 'parallel thinking' where the group examines a decision from each angle together, so more of the topic is covered with less ego and conflict.

FIGURE 1 · PROCESS VIEW

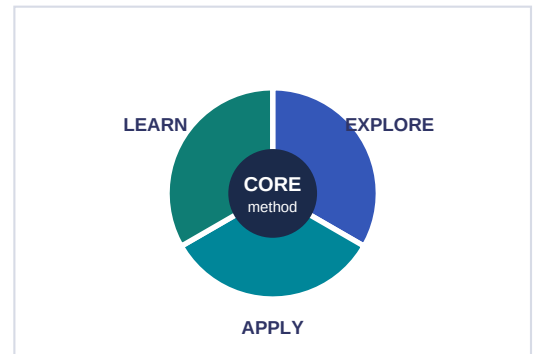


Figure 1. Six Thinking Hats framed as a continuous, iterative method — explore, apply and learn cycle back through the work rather than run once.

HOW IT IS USED

A facilitator (Blue hat) sequences the hats. The group spends a set time in each mode — e.g. all optimism, then all caution — capturing outputs before switching. It can be run for a whole meeting or a single decision.

WHEN IT IS USED

Decision reviews, idea evaluation, meeting design and conflict-prone discussions where balanced consideration is needed.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Facilitators, leadership teams, project groups and educators.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It replaces **combative** debate with structured, collaborative coverage of a problem — a distinct advance over unstructured discussion and pro/con lists.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Brainstorming *Slibrary 7*

Dot Voting *Slibrary 2*

Reframing Matrix *Slibrary 4*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

de Bono, E. (1985) *Six Thinking Hats*. Boston: Little, Brown.

de Bono, E. (1970) *Lateral Thinking*. London: Ward Lock Educational.